

Mechanical Image Stabilisation

This anti-shake system is hardware-based again. However, instead of getting the lens to jiggle in tandem with your hand, the image sensor itself moves to compensate the vibration. This system has a significant advantage over others — any lens compatible with an image-stabilised camera body can be used to replace the old one. However, if the VR mechanism fails, you'll have to send in the entire camera body for repair whereas in the OIS system, it's just the lens mechanism that would need to be fixed.

Non-Linear Editing Systems

Non-linear editing systems are software programs like Photoshop, Photoline and GIMP. These are used to correct images by inferring the stabilised image and minimising the motion blur due to camera shake. These, of course, are after the fact and not a measure of your photographic skill. However, if your photograph is a victim of vibration, and you're using a non-VR camera, then it's highly unlikely that any amount of editing could save it.

What to remember about IS

Camera manufacturers, and in particular the marketing guys, like to impress the customer by talking about vibration reduction, which is now increasingly packed into low-end compact digital cameras. The fact is that, IS in digital SLRs can help in (a) taking sharper photographs of static subjects in low light conditions (and the flash is not in use), (b) taking clearer photographs from a train or a moving car and (c) taking better pictures while using a lens with a long focal length.

However, it just doesn't work when the subject itself is moving fast. Static subjects can make great pictures if you set the camera on a tripod and give it a slow shutter speed (and therefore a longer exposure) – and so you don't need IS at all. Fast moving subjects can only be caught with a fast shutter speed, rather than image stabilisation.

3.2 Exposure Compensation

Every digital camera goes through a process called 'exposure metering' or just 'metering', which is nothing but the camera